

Audio file

[Trending-20 211 023-1TheDWordsVThePlanet.mp3](#)

Transcript

[Speaker 1](#)

[Decades ago, we predicted that we would be seeing these unprecedented heat waves and wildfires and floods and super storms.](#)

[Speaker 2](#)

[Professor Michael Mann has been one of the leading scientists in his field for several decades, but it wasn't until relatively recently that he came uncomfortably close to his subject.](#)

[Speaker 1](#)

[I would say that it was my sabbatical in Australia during the so-called Black Summer of late 2019, early 2020, where I first came face to face with climate change.](#)

[Speaker 3](#)

[This is an emergency on dozens of fronts. The heat is unbearable.](#)

[Speaker 1](#)

[Unprecedented heat and drought led to bushfires that blanketed the Australian continent. It was like a scene out of a dystopian Hollywood film, like being in Mad Max. It was dangerous to go outside on many days. That had a profound impact on me because again, it's one thing to study the impacts of climate change. It's something else entirely to live those impacts.](#)

[Speaker 2](#)

[While firefighters battled the flames, another struggle was underway, one which Professor Mann also found himself caught up in.](#)

[Speaker 1](#)

[I spent most of my time trying to provide some context for Australians to appreciate that what was happening here was a direct consequence of human-caused climate change. It's a challenge. for, to communicate the science and its implications to the public in the face of all the misinformation that was being put out claiming that this was all arson. It had nothing to do with climate change.](#)

[Speaker 3](#)

[Unless climate change is changing juvenile behaviour, it is hard to overlook crucial facts such as how the fires actually started.](#)

Speaker 1

And so it was interesting to be on the front lines both of the devastating impacts of climate change that were playing out in real time and the front lines of the climate disinformation campaign. For those of us who have been studying the topic, studying the science of climate change for decades now, what we're seeing is the worst thing that you can possibly see if you're a climate scientist. We're seeing our predictions come true.

Speaker 2

I'm Marianna Spring and this is BBC Trending. And in this special series we're going to be looking at how denial and disinformation are hindering the fight to prevent catastrophic climate change around the world.

Speaker 1

With this global warming hoax, as I've said many times, we've been here before, scientific hoaxes.

Speaker 2

The overwhelming majority of scientists agree that we are now at a turning point where only urgent and dramatic action can cut carbon emissions. In this first episode of The Denial Files, I'm speaking to Michael Mann, one of the most eminent climate scientists in the world. He's also spent many years observing the methods of those opposed to climate action, fossil fuel interests, the oil, gas and coal companies and their allies, the forces of inaction, as Mann calls them. We'll be talking about how their tactics have shifted as the evidence of climate change has mounted up. And we'll be exploring the new playbook of climate change denial. Professor Mann has himself been a target of climate change deniers for almost 1/4 of a century. The initial spark for these attacks came in 1998 when he led a study which tracked changes in average global temperatures over the previous thousand years.

Speaker 1

What you see is very small temperature changes until you get to the Industrial Revolution. And then temperatures shoot up and they shoot up in a way that is correlated closely with the increase in carbon pollution from fossil fuel burning and other human activities.

Speaker 2

The graph which showed this phenomenon was nicknamed the hockey stick because that's what it looked like. It was a landmark moment in climate science and the graph sent a clear message. Global temperatures were rising and human activity was to blame. When it was published, man found himself caught in the firing line of those who denied the existence of man-made climate change.

Speaker 1

I was not prepared for this sort of crescendo of attacks that I was subject to. There were allusions to sort of my ethnic background, the fact that I'm Jewish, part of a Jewish cabal, a Jewish conspiracy. And This was a common argument among websites promoting these sort of climate conspiracy theories And it really was intended to spur violence At one point I received an envelope with white powder in it and so I readily opened this frankly dubious looking envelope now that I think about it and Sort of I could see that there was like a white substance that was wafting into the air. And I realised at that point that I had potentially been subject to what could be a deadly substance. Eventually, my room had police tape over it, so it looked like a crime scene. We had to make sure the FBI came in.

Speaker 2

Thankfully, the powder was harmless. In the years since then, the truth of the hockey stick graph has been proved time and time again. The devastating impacts of wildfires and floods have become increasingly present. More people around the world are waking up to the threat of climate change. While there's been a decline in outright denial of climate change, Professor Mann says the denialists have not gone away. Instead, he says, his opponents have adopted new tactics, softer, more insidious forms of denial.

Speaker 1

So the fact that the person on the street can tell that something's happening, can see that climate change is real, it makes it very difficult for the forces of inaction, fossil fuel interests, those who advocate for them, right-wing media outlets. It's very difficult for them to deny that climate change is happening. So instead, they've turned to other tactics in their effort to prevent us from moving on. In the end, all they care about is that we remain addicted to fossil fuels.

Speaker 2

And whilst the methods may be different, the potential consequences remain catastrophic.

Speaker 1

What's important for us now is to recognize those tactics, because if we can recognize them, we can push them aside.

Speaker 2

So let's run through the playbook of these softer forms of denial. It's made-up of a lot of words that begin with the letter D. Delay tactics.

Speaker 1

Climate change is real, but it's not that much of a problem. We can just cope with it. We can adapt to it.

Speaker 4

This is not a time for pessimism. This is a time for optimism. Fear and doubt is not a good thought process. because this is a time for tremendous hope and joy and optimism and

action. But to embrace the possibilities of tomorrow, we must reject the perennial prophets of doom and their predictions of the apocalypse.

Speaker 1

Division Getting climate advocates fighting with each other, arguing with each other about lifestyle choices, finger pointing, carbon shaming, efforts to divide climate advocates so that they don't speak with one voice. Deflection, deflecting attention away from the needed policies towards individual behavior as if it's just on us. It's just a matter of you and me using recyclable bottles and changing our diet and changing our travel plans. They would happily have us so focused on our own individual carbon footprint that we fail to notice the overwhelming carbon footprint here, the footprint of carbon polluters.

Speaker 2

Some people might argue that while it's not overall as effective, it's still good if people are proactively engaged in doing stuff in their own lives that might make a difference to reducing climate change.

Speaker 1

Yeah, that's absolutely right. What we can't do is allow polluters to convince us that is all that needs to be done because the most powerful individual action we can take is voting and holding our policy policymakers accountable. You and I, we can't put a price on carbon. We can't block new fossil fuel infrastructure. Only our policymakers, our elected representatives, can do those things.

Speaker 2

And there's one more D on the list, one that's perhaps the polar opposite of denial.

Speaker 4

It's done. It's over. It's too late.

Speaker 1

So doomism, doom mongering, despair mongering, is Basically, the effort to convince us that it's too late to do anything.

Speaker 2

For doomists like this TikToker, all that humanity can do is sit back and wait for the end of the world.

Speaker 4

There is no stopping climate change, and we will witness climate change as an escalating series of catastrophic climate catastrophes filmed on someone else's phone and posted to social media.

Speaker 1

And what's so pernicious about this tactic is that it takes Those individuals who would otherwise be most active, most on the front lines, demanding change, environmental progressives, it takes them and it leads them down the path of disengagement.

Speaker 2

So why is understanding this new disinformation landscape important?

Speaker 5

What do we want? When do we want it? What do we want? When do we want it?

Speaker 2

One reason is that in November, world leaders will come together to discuss how we cut carbon emissions. The event, known as COP26, is regarded by many as our last best chance to avoid the devastating effects of runaway climate change. The stakes couldn't be higher.

Speaker 1

The only thing standing in our way right now is political willpower. We have the technology, to decarbonize our economy. We're seeing major policy progress now with the United States once again in a leadership position on this issue, with China coming to the table, with Europe, the EU, the UK, other countries putting forward bold pledges going into this next international climate summit. All of these favorable factors are starting to align, and the only thing now that's holding us back Are these new climate war tactics?

Speaker 5

What do we want? When do we want it?

Speaker 2

In my job as the BBC's specialist disinformation reporter, I spent the last 18 months covering conspiracy theories about COVID, elections, vaccines. And one thing that I've noticed is the increasing number of the same people who also seem to believe that climate change isn't an issue or that it's a hoax. Social media is where most people are likely to encounter these and other types of disinformation. Social media has also been weaponised to abuse climate activists, attack the messenger and you don't have to engage with their message.

Speaker 6

I often get comments underneath telling me that I'm too young to have an opinion or sometimes racially based comments as well.

Speaker 2

That's Theresa Rose Sebastian, a 17-year-old climate activist who was born in India and now lives in Ireland.

Speaker 6

I've had messages sort of sent to me telling me that nobody cares or that I should just, you know, shut up. And another criticism I get a lot is actually the fact that I'm apparently too loud, which I don't quite understand. Because in my sake, the gravity of this situation is so serious, I can't do anything but be loud. I have to keep raising this up because places like my home in India, it's not a 20 years potential issue, it's a today issue, it's a yesterday issue. Some of the experiences I've had in person, they've at times made me feel a bit scared to raise my voice and feel a bit honestly scared to say something. But for me it comes back to the fact that I love what I do and I do it because I love who I'm fighting for, what I'm fighting for.

Speaker 2

Despite the racial slurs and the insults, Teresa feels like she's had an easier time than some.

Speaker 6

I have experiences with friends who've gotten death threats, rape threats for their activism. And it's often just absolutely horrible, the sort of stuff a lot of my friends have received. Just because they believe in the right to a just and sustainable future, you can break a person apart through the internet, through these online abuses, and not get arrested or not get into trouble for it.

Speaker 2

Nowadays there are several prominent young climate activists, often young women, who found themselves subject to misogynistic, racist, ableist hate online, possibly from the same people who sought to attack you. How much does that worry you that that's happening?

Speaker 1

Worries me a lot, right? I mean, this is an effort to make sure that they don't participate in the discussion. And what's so unfortunate is that if you look at sort of the personality profile of a typical climate change denier in the United States, it's going to be an old conservative white male.

Speaker 2

Do climate disinformation tactics fall neatly on the right or left, or are there a variety of different actors?

Speaker 1

In terms of the perpetrators, typically It's those with a pro-fossil fuel agenda. Russia, for example, under Vladimir Putin, sees itself as benefiting. First of all, their main asset at this point are the fossil fuels that are still buried beneath their ground, and they want to monetize that asset. And they think that somehow they might even benefit in a warmer planet. And so that has led, for example, Russia as a state actor. to engage in efforts to prevent other countries from moving on. And they've used social media in particular to try to advance that agenda.

Speaker 2

However, in recent months, President Putin has also spoken of the need to tackle climate change and has moved to accepting that human activity is part of the problem. Professor Mann says he believes there are many reasons to be optimistic ahead of COP26, but the coming years will be crucial and progress depends on keeping up the pressure. So what could make the difference?

Speaker 1

Our secret weapon in this war is the moral authority of our children who are out on the streets marching, protesting, demanding that we act so that we do not mortgage the planet for them and for our children and grandchildren. And that's been a game changer.

Speaker 5

My message is that we'll be watching you. The eyes of all future generations are upon you. And if you choose to fail us, I say we will never forgive you.

Speaker 1

It's recentered the conversation where it always should have been, not simply on science or economics or policy or politics, but on our ethical obligation not to mortgage this planet for future generations. And I'm optimistic that now that we've re-centered the battle in those terms, that we will win this battle.

Speaker 2

That's it for this time. My thanks to producer Kayleen Devlin, series producer Vebeke Venema, and our editor, Ed Main. Thanks for listening. If you want to get in touch with your thoughts on this or any of our other programs, you can e-mail me. mariana.spring at bbc.co.uk. On the next episode of The Denar Files, we'll hear about the US states who are taking oil companies to court for allegedly misleading the public about what they're doing to stop climate change. Before we go, here's another podcast that likes to dig a little bit deeper.

Speaker 3

The problem is that the results of the question involved. This is dangerous because... On the Inquiry podcast, we try to find out what's really going on behind the stories you hear in the news. A lot of things happened. Could it also... We start with a question. What went wrong? Is peace under threat? Then we talk to 4 expert witnesses. I was horrified. His magic wasn't wrong. And we come up with an answer. That in many ways is the heart of the challenge that we face. The Inquiry from the BBC World Service. Beneath the surface, there is conflict. Search for the Inquiry wherever you get your podcasts.